



March 14, 2025

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

As organizers of a premier technology festival in Boise, Idaho—America’s second-fastest growing tech hub—Basecamp Tech Fest respectfully submits this response to the Request for Information regarding the development of an AI Action Plan. Our festival brings together over 4,000 innovators, entrepreneurs, industry leaders, and families to explore cutting-edge technology while celebrating the American spirit of innovation.

Our recommendations emphasize how regional technology ecosystems like the “**Boise Innovation Corridor**” can strengthen America’s global AI leadership through concrete policy actions supporting hardware-software integration, cross-regional collaboration, and workforce development. Our festival’s position within a Western states innovation network connecting Idaho, Wyoming, Montana, Utah, Washington, Oregon, Nevada, Colorado, and California provides insights into how distributed innovation can strengthen national competitiveness.

CONCRETE POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Hardware and Chips

Policy Action: Establish “**Regional Semiconductor Integration Zones**” that receive prioritized federal funding to connect domestic chip production with regional AI software development.

Rationale: Idaho’s semiconductor manufacturing capabilities demonstrate how regional technology hubs can create synergy between hardware and software development. This approach:

- Reduces dependency on foreign semiconductor suppliers
- Creates opportunities for specialized AI accelerator development
- Enables faster hardware-software co-optimization cycles
- Develops workforce expertise spanning hardware and software domains

2. Innovation and Competition

Policy Action: Create a “*Western States Technology Alliance Grant Program*” providing \$50-100M annually to support technology collaboration across nine Western states.

Rationale: The unique strengths of Western states create complementary innovation capabilities:

- Idaho’s semiconductor manufacturing and agricultural technology innovations
- Wyoming’s emerging blockchain ecosystem
- Montana’s natural resource technology innovations
- Utah’s software development expertise
- Washington and Oregon’s established tech sectors
- Nevada’s data center capabilities
- Colorado’s aerospace technology
- California’s venture capital networks

Federal support for cross-regional collaboration would create innovation networks more resilient than isolated technology hubs while reducing concentration risk.

3. Education and Workforce

Policy Action: Establish “*Regional AI Workforce Development Centers*” in emerging tech hubs with curricula developed in collaboration with local industry needs.

Rationale: The Basecamp Tech Fest model demonstrates effective approaches to regional workforce development:

- Industry-aligned technical certification pathways
- Mentorship programs connecting students with local employers
- Family-oriented technology education initiatives
- Career pathways for rural communities through remote work initiatives
- Programming that ensures participation by Americans of all backgrounds, including an under-utilized workforce made up of Deaf Americans

Federal support for these approaches would expand available technology talent beyond traditional tech centers.

4. Application and Use

Policy Action: Launch a “*Regional AI Applications Challenge*” program awarding grants for AI solutions addressing region-specific economic challenges.

Rationale: Our Northstar Hackathon demonstrates how competitive innovation can drive practical AI applications. Regional application challenges would:

- Accelerate adoption of AI in traditional industries
- Create regional centers of expertise in specialized applications
- Develop solutions that address the full spectrum of American economic needs
- Demonstrate AI’s practical benefits to communities outside tech hubs

5. Energy Consumption and Efficiency

Policy Action: Develop an *“AI Energy Independence”* program that provides tax incentives for data centers that maximize computational output per unit of energy through advanced cooling technologies and next-generation power management.

Rationale: Western states offer strategic advantages for efficient AI infrastructure:

- Idaho, Washington, and Montana’s abundant hydroelectric power resources
- Wyoming, Utah, and Colorado’s existing energy production infrastructure
- Nevada’s geothermal potential
- Availability of land for large-scale, efficient data center development

This approach would reduce computational costs while supporting America’s energy independence through technological efficiency rather than regulatory mandates. By focusing on maximizing computational performance per energy unit consumed, this program would drive innovation in energy-efficient hardware without imposing burdensome regulations that could hamper growth or damage traditional energy industries.

6. Data Centers

Policy Action: Create *“Critical AI Infrastructure Zones”* program that provides expedited permitting and tax benefits for data centers supporting AI development in distributed technology hubs.

Rationale: Basecamp Tech Fest’s positioning in Idaho demonstrates the advantages of distributed data center development:

- Lower land and operating costs
- Reduced concentration risk in critical infrastructure
- Access to renewable energy sources
- Proximity to emerging innovation centers
- Expansion of economic benefits beyond traditional tech hubs

7. National Security and Defense

Policy Action: Establish a *“Distributed AI Innovation Security Framework”* that incentivizes geographic distribution of critical AI development.

Rationale: Concentrating AI innovation in limited geographic areas creates strategic vulnerabilities that can be mitigated through:

- Distributed development centers across multiple states
- Regional specialization creating redundancy in critical capabilities
- Cross-regional talent mobility enabling rapid response to emerging needs
- Supply chain diversity reducing single points of failure

8. Research and Development

Policy Action: Create a “*Regional AI Research Network*” program that funds collaborative research between universities, industry, and government labs across state lines.

Rationale: Basecamp Tech Fest’s cross-regional model demonstrates how collaborative innovation accelerates development:

- Leverages complementary expertise from multiple institutions
- Creates pathways for commercialization through regional business networks
- Develops specialized research addressing regional economic needs
- Builds innovation capacity in communities outside traditional research centers

CONCLUSION

America’s AI leadership requires leveraging the full breadth of our national innovation ecosystem. The policy actions recommended above would strengthen American competitiveness by distributing innovation capabilities, connecting hardware and software development, and ensuring AI benefits extend throughout the country.

Basecamp Tech Fest’s model of bringing together technology leaders from across the Western states demonstrates how inter-regional collaboration can create resilient innovation networks that strengthen national competitiveness. By fostering technology development that spans urban and rural communities across diverse regions, these policies would ensure America maintains its global technology leadership.

We respectfully urge consideration of these concrete policy actions that recognize and support networks of emerging technology centers collaborating across state lines. By embracing a more distributed and interconnected approach to AI development, the United States can build a more resilient, competitive, and innovative technology ecosystem that secures our global leadership.

Respectfully submitted,

Bethany Guajardo, Founder

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